Hadja Sittie Nurlaylah "Emily" Marohombsar

Hadja Sittie Nurlaylah "Emily" Marohombsar (September 7, 1935 – May 24, 2013) was a Filipino educator, university administrator, and peace negotiator from Lanao del Sur who made history as the first, and to date only, woman to serve as president of the Mindanao State University (MSU) System, and as the first Moro woman appointed to the Government of the Republic of the Philippines (GRP) peace panel in negotiations with the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF). A graduate of the Philippine Women's University with the highest academic distinction, she pursued advanced studies at Ateneo de Manila University, the East-West Center at the University of Hawaii, and Harvard University before joining MSU's founding faculty in 1961. Over a career spanning more than four decades, she served successively as professor, Dean of the College of Liberal Arts, Vice President for Academic Affairs, Vice President for External Studies, and ultimately as the 4th MSU System President from 1993 to 1998, where she championed the vision of a "world-class MSU by 2020," forged international academic linkages, and institutionalized a generation of Bangsamoro women leaders through systematic mentorship and scholarship expansion. Her subsequent service as a civilian member of the GRP peace panel from 1998 to 2003 established a precedent for inclusive, gender-representative peace diplomacy in the Philippines. She died on May 24, 2013, in Marawi City, and was laid to rest in her hometown of Ganassi, Lanao del Sur.

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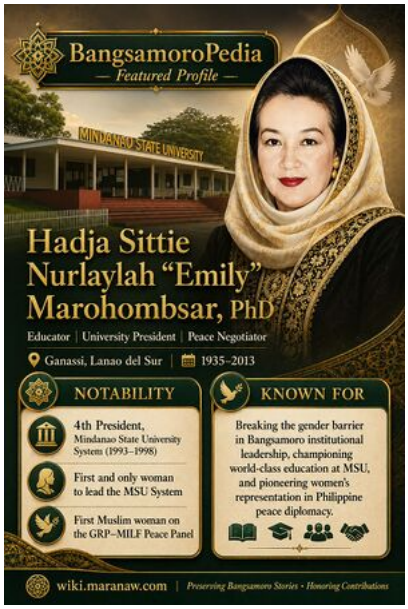
Early Life and Family Background

Marohombsar was born on September 7, 1935, in Ganassi, a municipality in the interior of Lanao del Sur, in what was then the undivided Lanao Province.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> Her birth came five years before the Philippines gained Commonwealth status and a decade before independence — a period when Maranao identity, rooted in the ancient lake region of Mindanao and woven through with Islamic faith and clan honor, was being tested by the expanding apparatus of colonial and post-colonial governance.

Her father, Luis Marohombsar, was a figure of exceptional distinction: the first Muslim graduate of the Philippine Military Academy (PMA) and the former military governor of the then-unified Lanao Province.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> His career represented a deliberate and consequential act of engagement with the Philippine national project at a time when many Maranao leaders viewed the Manila government with deep suspicion. By entering the state's most prestigious military institution and serving in civil authority, Luis Marohombsar demonstrated to his daughter that service to the nation and fidelity to Maranao identity are not contradictions but can be lived as a single, integrated vocation.

The Maranao Cultural Context

The Maranao people — whose name derives from *ranao*, the Maranao word for lake, referring to Lake Lanao — are among the most culturally distinctive of the Philippines' Muslim communities. Their society is organized around the *torogan* (royal households), the *taritib* (customary law), and an Islamic faith filtered through centuries of local tradition. In Maranao culture, *ilmu* — knowledge in the Islamic theological sense — is regarded not merely as an intellectual virtue but as a religious obligation, grounded in the Prophet Muhammad's reported instruction to "seek knowledge, even unto China."<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> Young people from prominent families were historically expected to master the Quran, the Arabic language, and the practical arts of governance and community leadership.

Hadja Sittie Nurlaylah "Emily" Marohombsar	
	
Born	September 7, 1935 Ganassi, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Died	May 24, 2013 (aged 77) Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Resting place	Ganassi, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam (Sunni)
Education	B.S. Education *(Summa Cum Laude)* Philippine Women's University
Post-graduate	Ateneo de Manila University; East-West Center, University of Hawaii; Harvard University
Honorary degree	Doctor of Humanities (*honoris causa*) Philippine Women's University (1978)
Occupation	Educator; University Administrator; Peace Negotiator

Yet the formal public sphere — the university presidency, the government negotiating table — had been almost exclusively male. The traditional Maranao noblewoman, the *bae*, commanded genuine moral authority within her community, but formal institutional power remained largely inaccessible to women. This was the structural limitation Emily Marohombsar was born into — and which her career would systematically dismantle.

Years active	1961–2003
Known for	First woman president of Mindanao State University System; First Moro woman on the GRP–MILF peace panel
MSU System Presidency	
Term	February 1993 – December 1998
Predecessor	Domocao Alonto Jr.
Successor	Camar Umpa
Appointed by	President Fidel V. Ramos
Personal	
Spouse	Abdul Marohombsar (lawyer; former Vice Governor, Lanao del Sur; COMELEC Commissioner)
Father	Luis Marohombsar (first Muslim PMA graduate; former military governor, Lanao Province)
Awards	TOWNS Award (1977); Sultan Kudarat Award (1988); Gintong Ina Award; Bangsamoro Woman of Distinction; East-West Center Outstanding Alumni

Name and Honorifics

Her formal name carries layered significance. "Hadja" denotes one who has completed the Hajj pilgrimage to Mecca, marking deep religious commitment and social standing in the Muslim world. "Sittie" is a Maranao honorific for a woman of noble birth. "Nurlaylah" is an Arabic compound meaning "Light of the Night" — *nur* (light) and *laylah* (night) — a name that would prove prophetic across the most turbulent decades of the Bangsamoro struggle.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> The nickname "Emily," accessible and two-syllabled, navigated the boundary between Filipino and international contexts and was the name by which she was known to students, colleagues, and peace-negotiation counterparts throughout her career.

Education

Undergraduate Studies

In the 1950s, Marohombsar traveled to Manila to study at the Philippine Women's University (PWU) — a significant act during a period when the cultural and political distance between Manila and Muslim Mindanao was profound. She graduated **Summa Cum Laude** with a Bachelor of Science in Education, the highest academic distinction the university conferred, in open competition with students from across the Philippines.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> She was among the very few Muslim Moro women of her generation to study at PWU.<ref>Luwaran/Key Philippine Military and Insurgency-Related Events. "Thousands mourn death of Moro educator Dr. Emily Marohombsar." *Luwaran*, May 28, 2013. https://retiredanalyst.blogspot.com/2013_05_28_archive.html</ref>

Impressed by her combination of academic excellence and physical grace, PWU officials reportedly encouraged her to enter a national beauty pageant — an invitation her devout Muslim family declined.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> The family's response was an early articulation of the principle that would guide her entire career: she was being educated to serve, not to be displayed.

Post-Graduate and International Studies

Marohombsar pursued post-graduate studies at Ateneo de Manila University, one of the Philippines' premier research institutions, deepening her grounding in education theory, linguistics, and social development.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> <ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "Moro women, second to none." *MindaNews*, March 29, 2008. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/</ref> She subsequently earned a scholarship to the East-West Center at the University of Hawaii, established by the United States Congress in 1960, where she engaged in the comparative study of educational systems, development economics, and the challenges of nation-building and cultural identity in the post-colonial Asian context.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref><ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "Moro women, second to none." *MindaNews*, March 29, 2008. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/</ref>

She then undertook studies at Harvard University, which at the time was developing influential models of institutional governance and international development policy.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref><ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "Moro women, second to none." *MindaNews*, March 29, 2008. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/</ref> From these experiences she drew a philosophy that would define her career: a university in a developing Muslim region was not simply a knowledge factory but a social institution — a proof-of-concept for the proposition that academic excellence and cultural identity need not conflict.

Honorary Doctorate

In 1978, the Philippine Women's University conferred upon her an honorary doctorate, *honoris causa*, in recognition of her leadership in Philippine higher education.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> The honor was symbolically complete: the student who had arrived in Manila in the 1950s from Lanao del Sur had returned, decades later, as one of the country's recognized educational leaders.

Career

Early Teaching: Jamiatul Philippine Al-Islamia

Before joining a state university, Marohombsar taught English at the Jamiatul Philippine Al-Islamia in Marawi City, an Islamic institution that predated MSU and served as one of the principal centers of Muslim education in the Lanao region.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> This posting was formative: it established the synthesis she would maintain throughout her career — that mastery of the modern world's languages and knowledge systems fulfilled rather than contradicted the Quranic command to seek knowledge. Teaching English to Bangsamoro youth was, in the post-colonial Philippines, both a practical instrument of upward mobility and a form of advocacy.

Founding Faculty of Mindanao State University (1961)

Mindanao State University was established through Republic Act No. 1387, as amended by R.A. 1893, authored by the late Senator Domocao Alonto, and formally opened in Marawi City on September 1, 1961 — a state institution expressly designed to bring quality higher education to the Muslim South.<ref>Mindanao State University. *Wikipedia*. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mindanao_State_University</ref> Marohombsar joined MSU's founding faculty in 1961, becoming part of what colleagues called the "pioneering faculty workforce" — the small cohort who built the institution's academic culture from the ground up, when the library was still sparse and the question of what it meant to be a Muslim university within a nominally secular state was still being worked out in practice. <ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> Her teaching subjects were English and Liberal Arts.

Administrative Rise: Dean and Vice President

Over the following decades, Marohombsar rose steadily through every level of MSU's academic and administrative structure. She served as Dean of the College of Liberal Arts, overseeing the foundational disciplinary programs on which MSU's professional schools depended. She subsequently served as Vice President for External Studies — a position documented in Philippine Supreme Court records from a case in which she was the petitioner — in which capacity she cultivated the East-West Center alumni network and began building the international linkages that would define her presidential tenure.<ref>*Dr. Emily M. Marohombsar v. Ahmad E. Alonto, Jr., et al.*, G.R. No. 93711. Supreme Court of the Philippines, February 25, 1991. https://lawlibrary.chanrobles.com/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=31259</ref> She also served as Vice President for Academic Affairs, responsible for the quality and direction of MSU's teaching and research programs across all campuses. <ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref>

Her tenure at MSU was not without institutional conflict. In 1989, then-MSU President Ahmad E. Alonto, Jr. attempted to reclassify her permanent position, leading Marohombsar to bring the matter before the Philippine Supreme Court. In a landmark decision dated February 25, 1991, the Supreme Court ruled in her favor, holding that her removal was unlawful and ordering her reinstatement as Vice Chancellor for the remainder of her term.<ref>*Dr. Emily M. Marohombsar v. Ahmad E. Alonto, Jr., et al.*, G.R. No. 93711. Supreme Court of the Philippines, February 25, 1991. https://lawlibrary.chanrobles.com/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=31259</ref> The ruling affirmed the security of tenure of permanent civil service officials and is cited in Philippine administrative law.

4th MSU System President (1993–1998)

In February 1993, President Fidel V. Ramos appointed Emily Marohombsar as the 4th President of the Mindanao State University System.<ref>Mindanao State University Main Campus. "The MSU System Presidents." *MSU Main Campus official website* (n.d.). https://www.msumain.edu.ph/the-msu-system-presidents/</ref> <ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "[Special Report] The women in the Bangsamoro peace process: History, herstory." *MindaNews*, January 28, 2014. https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-peace-process-history-herstory/</ref> The appointment was historic on multiple counts: she was the first woman ever to serve as MSU System President, the first woman to lead any major state university system in Mindanao, and one of a small number of women heading large, multi-campus public university systems anywhere in the Philippines at the time. She remains, to date, the only woman ever to have served in this role.<ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "[Special Report] The women in the Bangsamoro peace process: History, herstory." *MindaNews*, January 28, 2014. https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-

peace-process-history-herstory/</ref><ref>Mindanao State University Main Campus. "The MSU System Presidents." *MSU Main Campus official website* (n.d.). https://www.msumain.edu.ph/the-msu-system-presidents/</ref>

Her administration was guided by the vision of a "world-class MSU by the year 2020" — a phrase embedded in subsequent MSU strategic plans and student handbooks and one that continued to shape the university's institutional aspirations long after her presidency.<ref>Mindanao State University Main Campus. *MSU Student Handbook 2019–2020*. https://www.msumain.edu.ph/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/Student_Handbook_2019-2020.pdf</ref> She moved on three fronts: raising the quality of instruction and research to internationally competitive standards; building physical and technological infrastructure; and forging international educational partnerships.

Her emphasis on producing *topnotchers* — graduates ranked at or near the top of national professional licensure examinations in medicine, nursing, engineering, and law — was a deliberate strategy for building MSU's national reputation and demonstrating that Muslim students from Mindanao, trained at a Mindanao university, could compete with and outperform graduates from the country's most elite institutions.<ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "Moro women, second to none." *MindaNews*, March 29, 2008. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/</ref>

She forged formal academic linkages with universities in the United States and with institutions in the Brunei-Indonesia-Malaysia-Philippines East ASEAN Growth Area (BIMP-EAGA), opening pathways for MSU faculty to pursue advanced degrees abroad and creating student exchange opportunities previously unavailable to Mindanao scholars.<ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "Moro women, second to none." *MindaNews*, March 29, 2008. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/</ref> These partnerships embedded MSU within a regional Malay-Islamic academic geography that the internal boundaries of the Philippine state had historically obscured.

Colleagues consistently described her administration as energetic, demanding, meticulous, and above all, honest — she was characterized as a "human dynamo" in the academic community.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> Her personal lifestyle was notable for its modesty: her family was known for not building lavish homes despite many years of government service — a quality that stood in marked contrast to patterns of personal enrichment frequently observed among officials with access to government resources in the same era and region.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> Her tenure as MSU System President ended in December 1998, following the transition from the Ramos to the Estrada administration.<ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "[Special Report] The women in the Bangsamoro peace process: History, herstory." *MindaNews*, January 28, 2014. https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-peace-process-history-herstory/</ref>

Member, GRP–MILF Peace Panel (1998–2003)

Following her MSU presidency, Marohombsar joined the Government of the Republic of the Philippines (GRP) peace panel in negotiations with the Moro Islamic Liberation Front, becoming the first Moro woman ever to sit at the official government negotiating table with the MILF.<ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "[Special Report] The women in the Bangsamoro peace process: History, herstory." *MindaNews*, January 28, 2014. https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-peace-process-history-herstory/</ref><ref>Luwaran/Key Philippine Military and Insurgency-Related Events. "Thousands mourn death of Moro educator Dr. Emily Marohombsar." *Luwaran*, May 28, 2013. https://retiredanalyst.blogspot.com/2013_05_28_archive.html</ref> Her appointment broke the gender barrier in

Philippine peace negotiations at the highest level, bringing to the table a figure whose credentials were impeccable on both sides of the cultural divide: Harvard-trained, honored by the Philippine Women's University, deeply rooted in the Maranao community, and fluent in the Maranao language as well as English and Filipino.

UN Women researcher Irene Santiago, in a foundational study of women's participation in the Mindanao peace process, documented Marohombsar as a full member of the government panel — not an observer or adviser — meaning she participated in substantive negotiations, held a vote, and bore responsibility for the government's formal positions.<ref>Santiago, Irene M. "The participation of women in the Mindanao peace process." *UN Women*. https://wps.unwomen.org/pdf/research/Santiago.pdf</ref> She participated in technical working groups on ancestral domain and social development — the substantive committees where the practical terms of any eventual peace agreement on land rights, resource sharing, and community development were being defined.

When President Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo reconstituted the GRP peace panel as an all-civilian body in February 2001 under Presidential Adviser Jesus Dureza, she retained Marohombsar and added Irene Santiago of the Mindanao Commission on Women, making it the first time a majority of the civilian panel members were women with Bangsamoro ties or women's rights backgrounds.<ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "[Special Report] The women in the Bangsamoro peace process: History, herstory." *MindaNews*, January 28, 2014. https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-peace-process-history-herstory/</ref>

In 2003, before the 2004 presidential elections, Marohombsar and another female panel member resigned, reportedly disillusioned with what they viewed as the insincerity of the Arroyo administration's handling of the negotiations with the MILF.<ref>Luwaran/Key Philippine Military and Insurgency-Related Events. "Thousands mourn death of Moro educator Dr. Emily Marohombsar." *Luwaran*, May 28, 2013. https://retiredanalyst.blogspot.com/2013_05_28_archive.html</ref><ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "[Special Report] The women in the Bangsamoro peace process: History, herstory." *MindaNews*, January 28, 2014. https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-peace-process-history-herstory/</ref> The substantive proposals developed during her tenure in the technical working groups — on ancestral domain, social development, and the mechanics of genuine autonomy — laid groundwork that informed the 2014 Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro and the Bangsamoro Organic Law of 2018.

Historic Significance

Marohombsar's career occupies a foundational position in the history of Bangsamoro women's public leadership. Her MSU presidency broke a structural barrier specific to Muslim Mindanao: the formal institutional leadership of a major state university in a region where patriarchal clan structures, religious conservatism applied to gender roles, and the dislocations of prolonged conflict had combined to restrict Bangsamoro women's access to formal authority. Her appointment was, in the specific context of Marawi City and Lanao del Sur, more radical than national precedents — such as the 1986 presidency of Corazon Aquino — would suggest, given the distinct social pressures operating in the Muslim South.<ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "[Special Report] The women in the Bangsamoro peace process: History, herstory." *MindaNews*, January 28, 2014. https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-peace-process-history-herstory/</ref>

Her presence on the GRP peace panel established a precedent for gendered representation in Philippine peace diplomacy. Women's organizations, including the Mindanao-based Women's Peace Table and national NGOs engaged with the Bangsamoro peace process, have cited her participation as having "legitimized the Bangsamoro peace negotiations" in the eyes of Muslim constituencies — not merely through formal appointment but through the deeper legitimacy of community recognition.<ref>Santiago, Irene M. "The participation of women in the Mindanao peace process." *UN Women*. https://wps.unwomen.org/pdf/research/Santiago.pdf</ref> The Philippine

Commission on Women's 2025 statement on the twenty-ninth anniversary of the 1996 Final Peace Agreement names Marohombsar among "the first Moro women appointed to government peace panels" — a milestone in ensuring that women's perspectives would shape the future of Mindanao.<ref>Philippine Commission on Women. "Statement on the 29th anniversary of the signing of the 1996 Final Peace Agreement." September 2, 2025. https://pcw.gov.ph/philippine-commission-on-women-statement-on-the-29th-anniversary-of-the-signing-of-the-1996-final-peace-agreement/</ref>

By living simultaneously as a devout Muslim woman — completing the Hajj, observing her faith, maintaining Islamic dress — and as a Harvard-trained educator, university president, and peace negotiator, she demonstrated through practice what could not be established through argument alone: that Islamic identity and modern institutional leadership are complementary, not contradictory.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref>

Educational Philosophy and Contributions

Marohombsar's approach to education was guided by the conviction that "knowledge conquers all evils" — a principle she rooted both in Islamic teaching and in the founding ideals of MSU.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> The Islamic concept of *ilmu* — knowledge as a religious obligation and a path toward the divine — informed her view that a degree granted to a Maranao student was not merely a credential but a contribution to the collective capacity of a people to govern themselves, represent their interests in national forums, and withstand the political and economic marginalization that had historically defined Bangsamoro relations with the Philippine state.

Under her administration, Arabic language instruction, Islamic jurisprudence (*fiqh*), and Maranao cultural studies were offered alongside standard professional programs in education, nursing, engineering, agriculture, and law — not as cosmetic additions but as an integrated expression of the conviction that a Bangsamoro professional whose religious and cultural knowledge was shallow was not fully educated regardless of board examination performance.<ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "Moro women, second to none." *MindaNews*, March 29, 2008. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/</ref> She wanted MSU to produce graduates who were excellent by the standards of both the national mainstream and their own tradition, so that they would never be required to choose between being Muslim and being modern.

She placed particular and sustained emphasis on expanding access to higher education for Muslim women, expanding scholarship programs, recruiting women faculty, and personally mentoring numerous young Maranao women who went on to academic and professional careers. The effect compounded over time, generating successive cohorts of Bangsamoro women leaders in and beyond the university system.

Public Reception and Tributes

When Marohombsar died on May 24, 2013, thousands gathered in Marawi City before her burial rites, arriving from university campuses, mosques, and surrounding barangays of Lanao del Sur.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> The breadth of tributes was notable: they came from university presidents and village elders, from women's rights advocates and Islamic scholars, from the Philippine Commission on Women in Manila and from the MILF's communications portal in Cotabato.

MILF Peace Panel chairman Mohagher Iqbal, who had sat across the negotiating table from Marohombsar in the late 1990s and early 2000s, sent formal condolences and described her as "a very amiable personality" who was "so easy to deal with," adding: "We missed another good person and may Allah bless her soul."<ref>Luwaran/Key Philippine Military and Insurgency-Related Events. "Thousands mourn death of Moro educator Dr. Emily Marohombsar." *Luwaran*, May 28, 2013. https://retiredanalyst.blogspot.com/2013_05_28_archive.html</ref> That the MILF's own leadership mourned her passing as a personal loss spoke to the quality of human relationships she had built across a politically charged divide.

A tribute published in connection with her death described her as "an icon of integrity, beauty, and brain." <ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> The placement of "integrity" first in this formulation was characteristic of how her community valued her: among everything she had accomplished, the manner in which she conducted herself was regarded as the most important thing.

She was laid to rest according to Islamic burial rites in her hometown of Ganassi, Lanao del Sur, on May 25, 2013. <ref>Luwaran/Key Philippine Military and Insurgency-Related Events. "Thousands mourn death of Moro educator Dr. Emily Marohombsar." *Luwaran*, May 28, 2013. https://retiredanalyst.blogspot.com/2013_05_28_archive.html</ref>

Awards and Recognition

- **Ten Outstanding Women of the New Society (TOWNS) Award** (1977) — a national award recognizing Filipino women achievers.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref><ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "Moro women, second to none." *MindaNews*, March 29, 2008. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/</ref>
- **Honorary Doctorate, *honoris causa***, Philippine Women's University **(1978) — conferred in recognition of her leadership in Philippine higher education.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref>**
- **Sultan Kudarat Award for Most Outstanding Muslim Educator** (1988) — the Muslim community's own recognition of distinguished service to the Bangsamoro educational mission.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> <ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "Moro women, second to none." *MindaNews*, March 29, 2008. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/</ref>
- **Gintong Ina (Golden Mother) Award** — recognizing the integration of distinguished public service with exemplary family life.
- **Bangsamoro Woman of Distinction** citation.
- **East-West Center Outstanding Alumni Award** — from the institution that was the principal international turning point in her intellectual formation.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref>

In institutional form, the most enduring honor is the scholarship established in her name at MSU's Institute for Peace and Development in Mindanao (IPDM), which continues to support graduate education for scholars who might not otherwise have access to it.

Legacy

Marohombsar's legacy operates on several levels simultaneously. At MSU, the foundational mission she helped define — an academically excellent, culturally grounded Bangsamoro university embedded in both the national mainstream and the broader Malay-Islamic world — was institutionalized in strategic plans, student handbooks, and institutional culture. The international linkages she built during her presidency continued to generate opportunities for MSU faculty and students after her departure. The pipeline of Bangsamoro women educators and administrators that she cultivated through mentorship produced successive generations of women leaders in Mindanao higher education.

In the Bangsamoro peace process, the substantive proposals developed during her tenure on the GRP peace panel laid groundwork that influenced the 2014 Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro and ultimately the Bangsamoro Organic Law of 2018 (Republic Act 11054), which created the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) and included explicit provisions for women's representation in its governance structures.<ref>Philippine Commission on Women. "Statement on the 29th anniversary of the signing of the 1996 Final Peace Agreement." September 2, 2025. https://pcw.gov.ph/philippine-commission-on-women-statement-on-the-29th-anniversary-of-the-signing-of-the-1996-final-peace-agreement/</ref>

The principles she embodied throughout her career — women's full participation in public life, the inseparability of cultural identity and modern professional competence, the state's obligation to invest in the education of its Muslim citizens — have been progressively codified in Philippine law, including the Magna Carta of Women (Republic Act 9710, 2009) and the BARMM's governance framework.

Her name is cited in the Philippine Commission on Women's 2025 statement as part of a lineage of women peacebuilders that runs from her 1998 appointment through Irene Santiago and Miriam Coronel-Ferrer — who served as chief government negotiator when the 2014 Framework Agreement on the Bangsamoro was signed — and continues into the current generation of Bangsamoro women in governance and civil society.<ref>Philippine Commission on Women. "Statement on the 29th anniversary of the signing of the 1996 Final Peace Agreement." September 2, 2025. https://pcw.gov.ph/philippine-commission-on-women-statement-on-the-29th-anniversary-of-the-signing-of-the-1996-final-peace-agreement/</ref><ref>Arguillas, Carolyn O. "[Special Report] The women in the Bangsamoro peace process: History, herstory." *MindaNews*, January 28, 2014. https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-peace-process-history-herstory/</ref>

The MSU Institute for Peace and Development in Mindanao (IPDM) maintains the scholarship and lecture series in her name as active expressions of her conviction that education is the most durable instrument of social transformation in Mindanao.

Personal Life

Marohombsar married Abdul Marohombsar, a lawyer who served as Vice Governor of Lanao del Sur and subsequently as a Commissioner of the Commission on Elections (COMELEC) — a parallel public service career that made their household a living argument for the Bangsamoro community's future in trained, ethical, and civically engaged citizens.<ref>Macabalang, Ali G. "Death of Muslim lady educator mourned." *Mindanao Pagadian Frontline*, May 27, 2013. http://pagadianfrontline.blogspot.com/2013/05/death-of-muslim-lady-educator-mourned.html</ref> Their children were raised in a home where intellectual discipline, Islamic values, and civic commitment were integral to domestic life.

She was the maternal aunt of Robert Maulana M. Alonto, who served as a senior member of the MILF Peace Negotiating Panel and concurrently as a member of the Bangsamoro Transition Commission (BTC). <ref>Luwaran/Key Philippine Military and Insurgency-Related Events. "Thousands mourn death of Moro educator Dr. Emily Marohombsar." *Luwaran*, May 28, 2013. https://retiredanalyst.blogspot.com/2013_05_28_archive.html</ref> Through this family connection, she was personally linked to both sides of the peace process she participated in — a position she navigated with the same integrity that characterized all of her public conduct.

She completed the Hajj pilgrimage, earning the honorific "Hadja," and maintained her Islamic practice throughout her academic and public career. She is universally remembered by those who knew her as having been constitutionally incapable of separating her professional conduct from her religious values — the two were, in her life, the same thing.

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Moro Islamic Liberation Front
- 1996 Final Peace Agreement (Philippines)
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Philippine Commission on Women
- Irene Santiago
- Miriam Coronel-Ferrer
- Maranao people
- Lanao del Sur
- Women in the Bangsamoro peace process
- Jamiatul Philippine Al-Islamia

External Links

- MSU System Presidents – Official MSU Main Campus Page (https://www.msumain.edu.ph/the-msu-system-presidents/)
- "Moro Women, Second to None" – MindaNews (2008) (https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2008/03/moro-women-second-to-none/)
- "The Women in the Bangsamoro Peace Process: History, Herstory" – MindaNews via CMFR (2014) (https://cmfr-phil.org/womensvoices/resources/special-report-the-women-in-the-bangsamoro-peace-process-history-herstory/)
- "The Participation of Women in the Mindanao Peace Process" – UN Women (Irene Santiago) (https://wps.unwomen.org/pdf/research/Santiago.pdf)
- PCW Statement on the 29th Anniversary of the 1996 Final Peace Agreement (2025) (https://pcw.gov.ph/philippine-commission-on-women-statement-on-the-29th-anniversary-of-the-signing-of-the-1996-final-peace-agreement/)
- *Marohombsar v. Alonto*, G.R. No. 93711 – Supreme Court of the Philippines (1991) (https://lawlibrary.chanrobles.com/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=31259)
- MSU Student Handbook 2019–2020 (https://www.msumain.edu.ph/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/Student_Handbook_2019-2020.pdf)

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